

Possible Manifestations of Adult Attachment Types

Secure Attachment

Seeks emotional closeness with others
Able to establish emotional intimacy
Comfortable with mutual dependence
Comfortable being alone
Positive self-image and other image
Warm and open with others
Accepts criticism without significant distress
Strong sense of self
Self-esteem
Self-observational skills
Self-reflective skills
Able to trust in relationship
Relationships tend to be stable, lasting
Open with others about feelings
Positive feelings about relationships
Balanced experience of emotions—neither too little nor too much
Values attachment

Dismissing Attachment

Avoidance of getting close or being intimate
Discomfort with closeness
Ambivalence
Dismissing behaviors
Aloofness and contempt
Mistrust about depending on others
Difficulty getting close
Preference for remaining distant
Fear of closeness
Lack of emotion or minimization of emotional expression
Discomfort with opening up, especially about private thoughts
False self
Pulls away if someone gets close
Illusion of self-sufficiency
Alexithymia

Anxious-Preoccupied Attachment

Excessive worry about relationships
Worry that one's partner won't care as much as he or she does
Obsessive preoccupation with and rumination about the relationship
Excessive need for approval

Ignoring signs of trouble in the relationship
Fear of scaring people away
Fear of abandonment/rejection/criticism
Resentment when partner spends time away from the relationship
Angry withdrawal
Frustration if partner is not available
Feels extremely upset/depressed when receives disapproval
Easily upset, with intensified displays of distress or anger
Jealousy
Fear of being alone
Compulsive caretaking
Submissive, acquiescent, suggestible
Seeks attachment at the expense of autonomy
Work, school, or friends get less attention than the relationship partner
Compulsive care-seeking
Partner describes self as “smothered” or “suffocated”
Eager to be with partner all the time
Needs excessive reassurance
Clinging, demanding, nagging, sulking
Desire to merge
Attempts to win favor or impress
Forces responses from partner
Self-centeredness, showing off, center of attention

Disorganized/Fearful Attachment

Disorganized Internal World

- Dysregulated psychophysiological state
- Affect dysregulation (too much or too little)
- Lapses in self-observation or monitoring
- Discontinuous self-states and affect states
- Cognitive distortion, confusion, and drive-dominated thinking

Disorganized Behavior

- Impaired self-agency and goal-directed behavior
- Inhibition of exploration and play

Disorganized Attachment Behavior

- Activation of contradictory attachment strategies
- Controlling behaviors
- Submissive or excessive caretaking behaviors
- “Stable instability” in relationships
- Defensive aggression and helplessness
- Inability to elicit desired responses